

Ethical Practice in Healthcare Settings and Professionalism

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PRESENTATION LAYOUT

Background to Ethics in Healthcare

The applicability of ethical practice and professionalism

Introduction to Ethical practice and Professionalism

Core Ethical Principles

Ethics for AI in healthcare

Conclusion



BACKGROUND

- The health care setting is constantly advancing and evolving and therefore subject to conflicts arising from within the arenas of ethics, correspondingly engaging health practitioners to have moral or ethical obligations to themselves, others and to the society in general as they practice their professions (HPCSA, 2025).



ETHICAL PRACTICE & PROFESSIONALISM

Applicability of ethical practice and professionalism is required as follows:

- In curative and preventative healthcare services
 - In healthcare education and training
 - In public health research
 - In AI for healthcare
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- **In Population vs Individual**



INTRODUCTION

ETHICAL PRACTICE

- Morals and values of healthcare professionals that may impact the health and well-being of patients, families, and communities.
- These morals and values are directed by core ethical principles

PROFESSIONALISM

- Competency and compassion
- Varkey (2021) outlines these aspects of professionalism:

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- Cure of disease when possible
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- Maintenance or improvement of functional status and quality of life (relief of symptoms and suffering)
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- Promotion of health and prevention of disease
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- Prevention of untimely death
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- Education and counseling of patients (condition and prognosis)
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- Avoidance of harm to the patient in the course of care
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- Providing relief and support near time of death (end-of-life care)
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ETHICAL PRINCIPLES

According to Varkey (2021) and Monash Health Library (2025), the following ethical principles are applicable:

- **Non-Maleficence** – Ensuring that healthcare interventions do not cause unnecessary harm to patients, clients and community at large.
- **Justice** – Ensuring fairness in the distribution of healthcare resources, benefits and treating patients and communities equitably regardless of background.
- **Confidentiality** – Protecting patient information and only sharing it when necessary for care or required by law.
- **Autonomy** – Respecting a patient's and community rights to make informed decisions about their care, including the right to refuse treatment or participation in research.



ETHICAL PRINCIPLES...

- **Beneficence** – Acting in the best interests of the patient to promote their health.
- **Informed Consent** – Ensuring patients receive all necessary information about a treatment before agreeing to it and communities receive all information concerning research before agreeing to participate
- **Professional Integrity** – Upholding honesty and ethical conduct in all aspects of healthcare practice
- **Transparency** - Openness in decision-making and data sharing.
- **Solidarity & Reciprocity** - Shared responsibility and mutual support for the common good



A LOOK AT EXAMPLES OF PUBLIC HEALTH ETHICS CASES, ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS AND RESOLUTIONS



ETHICS for AI in Healthcare

- Goktas & Grzybowski (2025) highlights that artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming healthcare, enabling advances in diagnostics, treatment optimization, and patient care though its integration raises **ethical, regulatory, and societal challenges** with concerns including **data privacy risks, algorithmic bias, and regulatory gaps** that struggle to keep pace with AI advancements.
- The authors conclude that “trustworthy AI in healthcare requires more than technical advancements demanding **robust ethical safeguards, proactive regulation, and continuous collaboration**”.



ETHICS for AI in Healthcare

- Corformat, Martineau & Régis (2025) indicates that AI systems are destined to become part of healthcare delivery necessitating healthcare systems, professionals, and administrators to be impacted by the implantation of AI systems.
- These authors propose three avenues of reflection including; **1) Education and training of healthcare professionals; 2) Support and guidance of healthcare professionals and 3) Tool adaptation**



CONCLUSION

The CDC Office of Science supports CDC's public health ethics capacity to foster an environment and culture that:

Supports and develops ethical practices.
Raises staff awareness of public health ethics
Provides support for analyzing ethical issues.

Regulatory Bodies such
as HPCSA & NHREC



**WHO 2023 CODE OF
ETHICS**

**Individual
moral
obligation???**



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